never allow any woman a glimpse of individuality. They would all be given titles, their names almost completely forgotten, and would be accorded the most perfunctory of descriptions—'cupolas of chastity' and 'pillars of chastity' being preferred monikers. Akbar's wives, especially, would be subjected to a ruthless and complete censorship, reduced to barely acknowledged shadows whose only noteworthy acts were to produce 'pearls', Akbar's children, from their blessed wombs. Interestingly, Abu'l Fazl would hold his own family to this very same rigorous standard, never once referring to a wife, a sister, or a daughter in his own biography. It would fall to Gulbadan's memoir, forgotten for a long time, to eventually shine a light on the complex geometry of these women's lives.

Abu'l Fazl's *Akbarnama* overshadowed medieval history for centuries with the sobering weight of his learning and conviction to the detriment of all other histories and sources of memory. At the same time, the tone of the *Akbarnama* was derided for being sycophantic to Akbar, and the Padshah himself was belatedly scolded by Western historians for tolerating such excessive flattery. But to see the *Akbarnama* as simply an exercise in obsequiousness by an overenthusiastic courtier would be short-sighted, for what Abu'l Fazl intended was far more ambitious, even incendiary. In most histories of the time, in which the ruler was Muslim, genealogies would begin with praises of Allah, and Prophet Muhammad, and then work their way through the various caliphs and sultans, through purely Islamic lineages, to the ruler in question. Abu'l Fazl, instead, after praising Allah, begins with Adam, the original 'man', omitting the Prophet and the caliphs altogether. He traces Akbar's lineage through fifty-two generations, placing the Padshah firmly in the position of the ruler of all humanity, and not just his Muslim subjects.

In addition, as scholars such as A. Azfar Moin and Ruby Lal have shown, Abu'l Fazl used a complex set of symbols to articulate a vision of the Padshah as semi-divine, appearing as he did at the cosmically and spiritually charged advent of the new Islamic millennium to be the temporal as well as spiritual guide to all the peoples of Hindustan, not only Muslims. In his genealogy of Akbar, Abu'l Fazl did not just show Akbar descending from an illustrious line of forefathers as Babur and Humayun had sought to do but instead inversed this equation to demonstrate that it was, on the contrary, Akbar's luminous destiny that tinged his predecessors with glory. This would explain the episodes of 'divine effulgence' that occurred before